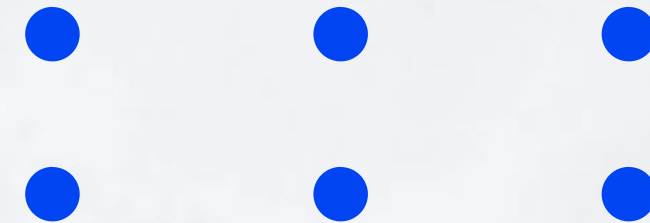




MEDIA BIAS

When a news source presents information in a way that favors a particular perspective, interpretation, or viewpoint



Presented By: **Mandy 10.1**

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'Black widows': Women accused of marrying Russian army recruits to claim death payouts

UPDATED AUG 6, 2025

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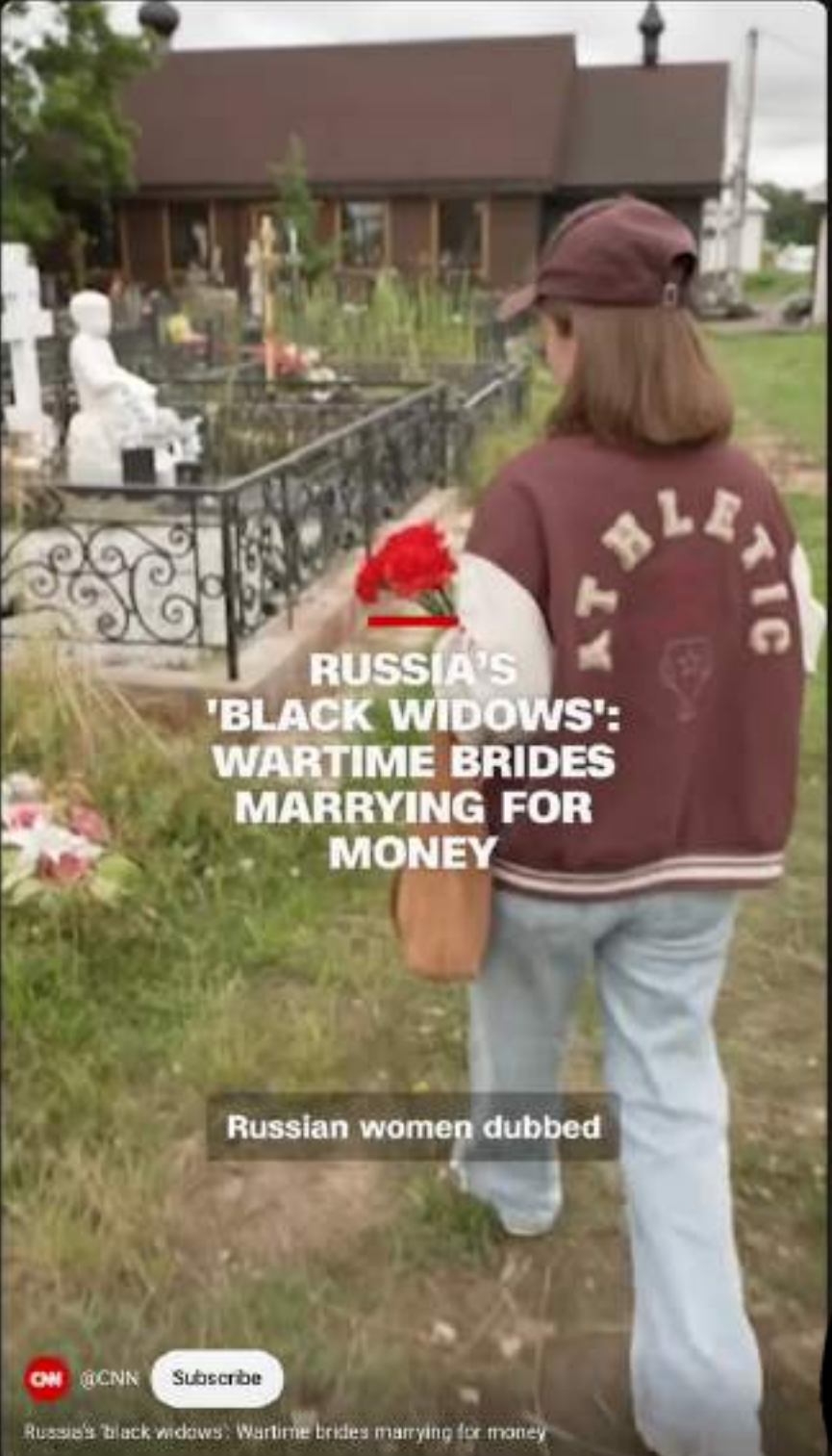
Outrage In Russian Media Over 'Black Widows' Seducing Soldiers For Death Benefits

By [Current Time](#), [Andrey Cherkasov](#) and [Stuart Greer](#)

April 21, 2025 00:03 CET

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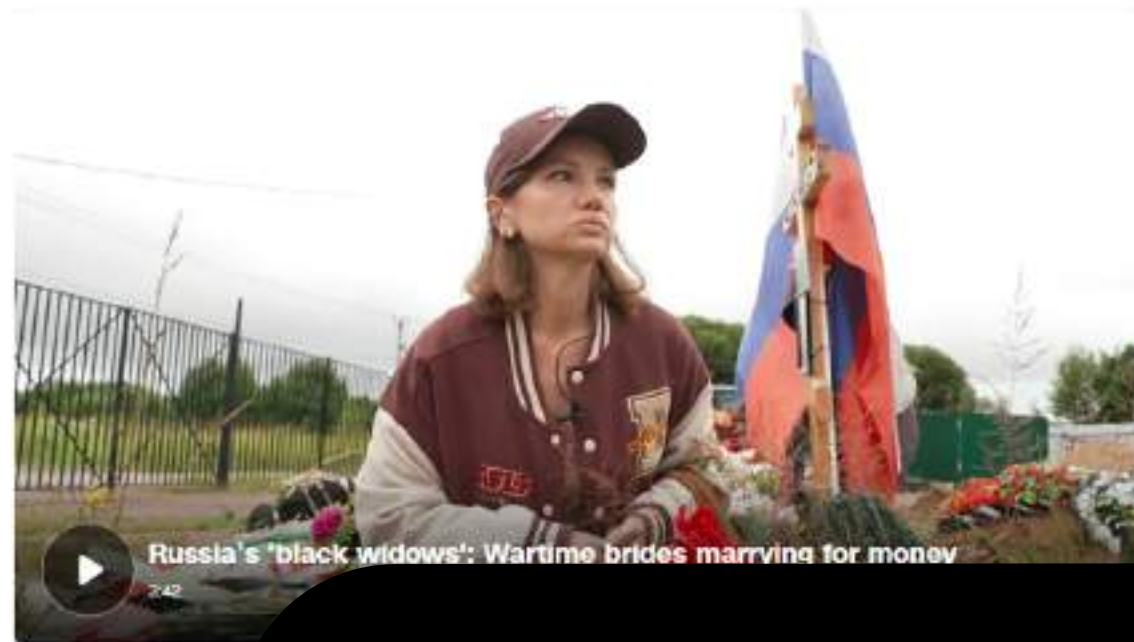
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THIS MEDIA IS SLIGHTLY BIASED !!!

How is this bias shown?

- framing
- Language



Framing

The bride, whom Maria says she had never met or even heard her father mention, was 22 years his junior and had become her dad's legal next of kin, entitling her to official compensation.

"I've never even spoken to this woman," Maria, 37, said. CNN is using only her first name for privacy reasons.

"I don't know what to say to her because I immediately suspected it was a scam." CNN attempted to reach Yury's widow for comment.

The soldier, Georgy Kostyrko, met Angelina Varyukhina online and married her 10 days later, before rejoining his unit.

According to Kostyrko's mother, the new wife soon began posting photographs and videos of herself with other men on social media, and her son filed for divorce. But he was killed in action before the paperwork was finalized, leaving her as the legal recipient of the death compensation.

Varyukhina offered a different account, saying accusations about her brief marriage were an attempt to "blacken" her reputation, and that she and Kostyrko reconciled after falling out. She said images of her online with other men were intended to make Georgy jealous.

In a video podcast recorded in the Siberian city of Tomsk last year, one Russian real estate agent offered astonishingly cynical advice to would-be property buyers.



"I'm a 30-year-old woman, but if I want to buy an apartment, where am I supposed to get the money?" the host, Darya Cherdantseva, asked.

"It's simple," the agent, Marina Orlova, responded. "Find a man who's serving in the Special Military Operation and when he gets killed, you get 8 million rubles," or \$102,000, she said with a laugh.

"Lots of women are buying cheap apartments like that these days. It's business," Orlova added.



Language

But there are mounting concerns in Russia that the benefit is increasingly being exploited by ruthless scammers, whom Russian officials and state media dub “black widows.” They dupe vulnerable men into sham marriages before seeing them off to war, then claim compensation if their new husbands are killed, cutting out other relatives.





focuses heavily on
the women's
actions...

But what about the men?





22.46 Sun 23 Aug edition.cnn.com

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St. Petersburg, Russia — When Maria was told by the Russian military that her 59-year-old father had been shot on the front lines of the Ukraine war and had been killed of his wounds, she was distraught and doubly shocked.

Not only was she unaware that her dad, Yury, had enlisted in the army, she was also informed he got married just two days before being sent to fight.

"I'm still in shock and still can't accept what happened," Maria said, sobbing at the kitchen table in her small St. Petersburg apartment. "At first, it felt like a dream. Even now, I sometimes wake up thinking I must have just dreamt it all. But it is really happening," she added tearfully.

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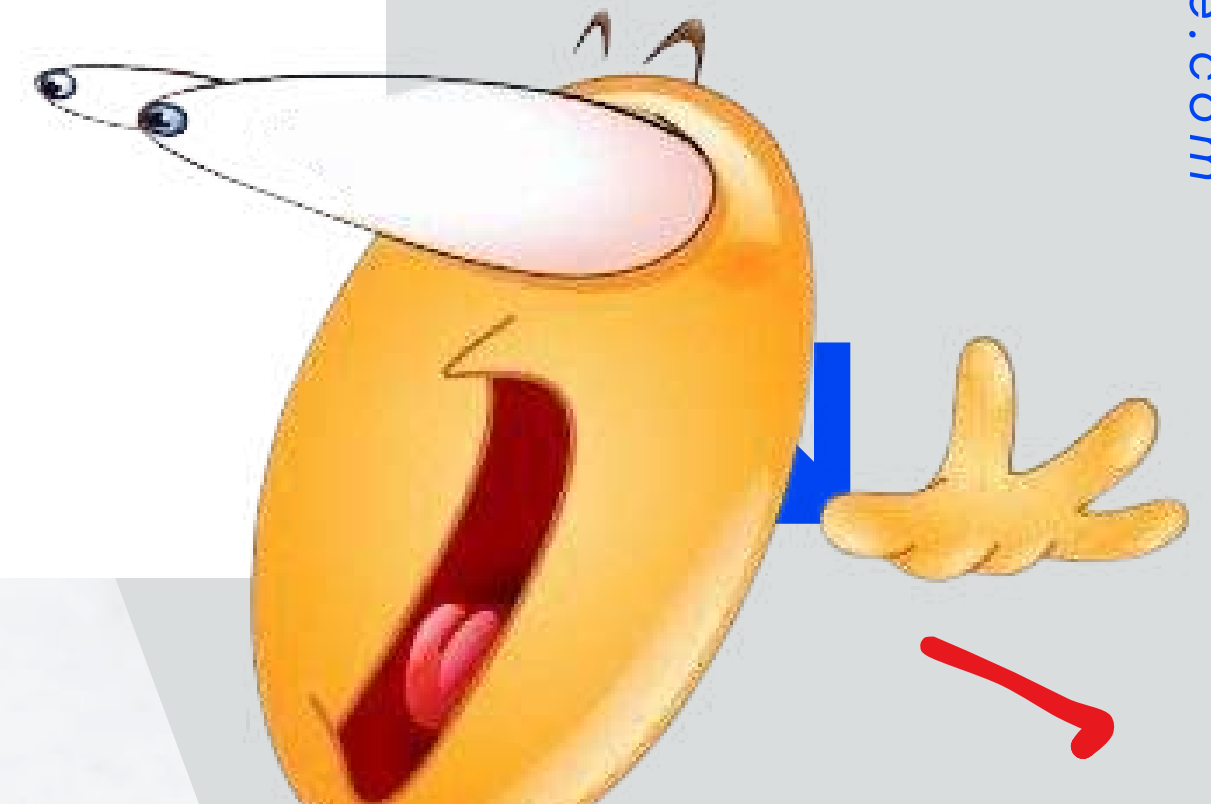
"I don't know what to say to her because I immediately suspected it was a scam." CNN attempted to reach Yury's widow for comment.

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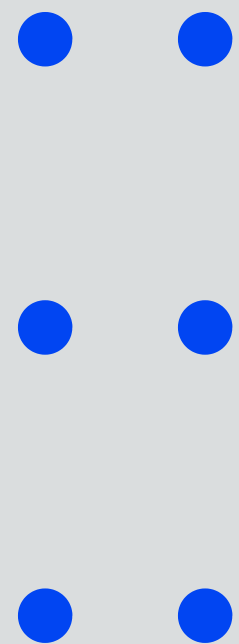
In Russia, the data is different. The average age gap in couples is **4 to 5 years**, and gaps of 10 to 15 years are common and socially accepted. Several factors explain this difference:



Journalists:

- hold the power
- control the language and selection





Whose perspective am I reading from and whose perspective might be missing?



Thank you so much

